USER MANUAL & STANDARD OPERATING PROCEDURES

Project Management Module

The complete operating guide for the five-stage delivery lifecycle: intake and approval chains, resource matchmaking, capacity governance, Agile and Waterfall execution, timesheets, stage gates and closure.

3Boxes HRMS | Version 1.0

Prepared by the 3Boxes Platform Team · September 2026

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1. Introduction

1.1 Purpose of This Manual

This manual is the standard operating procedure (SOP) reference for the Project Management module of the 3Boxes HRMS platform. It explains, end to end, how a project travels through the five-stage delivery lifecycle: Initiation (intake), Planning, Execution, Review and Approval, and Closure. Every procedure is written as numbered steps with the exact navigation path, so a new administrator or project manager can follow along without prior training. The manual also documents the Workflow Configuration console, which allows each organisation to adapt approval chains, capacity rules, workspace automation, timesheet routing and closure checklists to its own governance style without any code change.

The module is deliberately opinionated about process. Projects cannot skip intake approval, resources cannot be silently over-committed beyond configured thresholds, timesheets route to a defined approver, and no project can close without a sign-off supported by objective readiness metrics. Understanding this philosophy will help users interpret why certain actions are blocked and what the system expects next.

1.2 Scope and Intended Audience

The manual covers all user-facing capabilities of the module: the project intake form, methodology selection (Agile/Scrum or Waterfall), resource requests and skill matchmaking, soft and confirmed allocations, the capacity planner, delivery board and task management, sprints, milestones and phases, timesheets, stage-gate reviews, project closure with post-mortem feedback, collaboration hooks (chat room and kanban board), and third-party integrations with Jira and Azure DevOps.

Four role groups use the module. **Super Admins and Tenant Admins** configure workflows, manage tenant-wide defaults and hold final approval authority. **Project Managers (PMs)** own intake submission, resourcing, delivery tracking and closure. **Team Leads** act as first-tier reviewers in stage gates and approve work in the delivery board. **Team Members (employees)** execute tasks, log time against projects and keep their skills profile current. Where a procedure is role-restricted, this manual marks it explicitly, for example "Admin only" or "PM and approver".

1.3 How to Use This Manual

Chapters are ordered by the project lifecycle. Chapter 2 gives the conceptual overview and role matrix - read it first. Chapter 3 is the administrator guide to the Workflow Configuration console. Chapters 4 through 8 walk one stage each, in strict operational order. Chapter 9 condenses everything into one-page quick-reference cards per role, Chapter 10 is the full permission matrix, Chapter 11 answers the most common troubleshooting questions, and Chapter 12 defines every specialised term used in the module. Screenshots were taken from a live demo tenant; your data, employees and project names will naturally differ.

Conventions used in this manual

Numbered steps indicate an exact procedure. Shaded "Navigation" strips show the click path, for example Projects / Mobile Banking App Revamp / Resources. Callout boxes flagged NOTE, WARNING or TIP highlight rules, blockers and efficiency advice. Role tags such as (Admin only) tell you who may perform a step.

2. Module Overview and Delivery Lifecycle

2.1 The Five-Stage Delivery Lifecycle

Every project in 3Boxes HRMS follows one governed pipeline. The lifecycle is enforced by the workflow engine: a project physically cannot reach Execution before its intake is approved, cannot log time against a gated Waterfall phase before the phase is approved, and cannot close before the compliance checklist and sign-off are complete. The five stages and the gates between them are shown below.

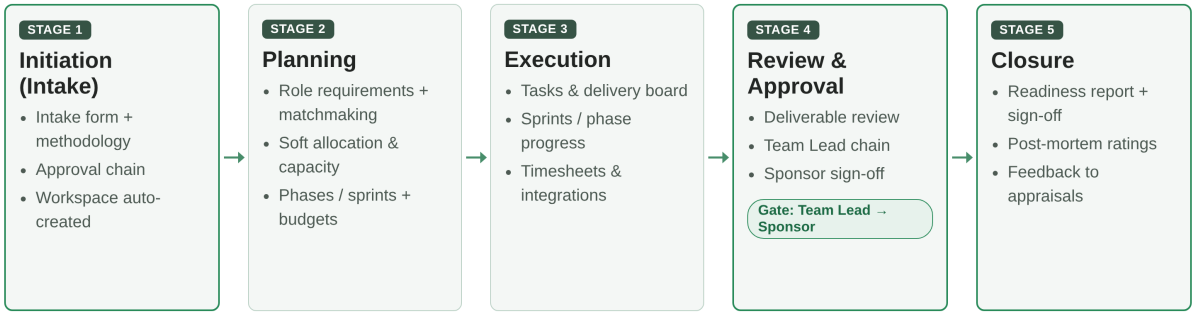


Figure 2-1: The five-stage project delivery lifecycle and its control gates

Stage 1 (Initiation) standardises how work enters the system: a sponsoring manager completes the intake form, chooses a delivery methodology, and routes the request through a configurable approval chain. On final approval the platform automatically creates the project workspace - a collaboration chat room and a kanban delivery board seeded from the project tasks - and notifies every allocated member. Stage 2 (Planning) converts the approved intent into a resourced plan: role requirements are matched against the employee skill inventory, candidates are soft-reserved from the bench, and the plan is shaped as sprints (Agile) or phases and milestones (Waterfall). Stage 3 (Execution) is where teams work: tasks flow across the delivery board, sprints run to a rhythm, timesheets capture actual effort, and external work items can be synchronised from Jira or Azure DevOps. Stage 4 (Review and Approval) routes completed deliverables through a stage-gate chain - typically Team Lead first, then the Project Sponsor. Stage 5 (Closure) produces a readiness report, collects post-mortem ratings that feed the Performance module, and locks the project with a formal sign-off.

2.2 Delivery Methodologies: Agile and Waterfall

The methodology is chosen on the intake form and is mandatory. It shapes the vocabulary and the controls of everything that follows. Agile projects run fixed-length sprints with story points, a one-active-sprint rule per delivery pod, velocity and say-do ratio tracking, and a burndown view. Waterfall projects use sequential

phases with budget caps, milestone-driven progress, and a phase gate that blocks time logging on a phase until the preceding phase is approved. The comparison below summarises the practical differences an operator will feel.

Aspect	Agile / Scrum	Waterfall
Planning unit	Sprints of fixed duration (configurable, default 2 weeks)	Sequential phases with rigid date windows
Estimation	Story points per task	Phase budgets and milestone dates
Progress signal	Sprint velocity and say-do ratio, burndown	Milestone variance and phase approval status
Time logging gate	None - log against any active sprint task	Phase gate: previous phase must be approved
Budget control	Committed points per sprint	Budget cap per phase, slippage alerts
Typical use	Product development, iterative scope	Fixed-scope migrations, compliance work

Table 2-1: How the two methodologies differ in daily operation

> **One methodology per project**
>
> The methodology selector is required at intake and cannot be left empty. A project runs either Agile or Waterfall; hybrid delivery is achieved by structuring work inside the chosen model (for example, running a hardening phase inside an Agile project as a dedicated sprint).

2.3 Roles and Permissions at a Glance

The module distinguishes five operating roles. The Super Admin (platform level) manages tenant-wide workflow defaults and tenant health. The Tenant Admin configures company-scoped workflows and holds executive approval authority. The Project Manager owns the project day to day. The Team Lead reviews deliverables at stage gates and guides the delivery pod. Team Members execute and log work. The full action-by-action matrix appears in Chapter 10; the summary below is the mental model.

Role	Owns	Cannot do
Super Admin	Tenant-wide workflow configuration, DB provisioning, cross-tenant reporting	Cannot be a project approver unless also mapped in the tenant
Tenant Admin	Company workflow config, executive intake approval, closure sign-off authority	Cannot bypass an enabled approval chain
Project Manager	Intake submission, resourcing, tasks, sprints, stage-gate submission, closure initiation	Cannot approve own intake tier or own timesheets
Team Lead	First-tier stage-gate review, task guidance, sprint hygiene	Cannot alter workflow configuration
Team Member	Task execution, board moves, timesheet submission, skill profile upkeep	Cannot see cost rates or other projects unless allocated

Table 2-2: Role ownership summary

2.4 Where Everything Lives

The Project Management section of the sidebar contains ten entries. PM Dashboard aggregates portfolio KPIs and the personal kanban. Projects lists every project card and opens the ten-tab delivery workspace. Sprints and Tasks give cross-project views of those artefacts. Timesheets is the time-tracking home for employees and approvers. Capacity Planner shows live availability and over-allocation alerts. Utilisation charts historical bench and billable trends. Workflow Configuration (admin) opens the governance console described in Chapter 3. Project Settings and Project Reports round out administration and reporting.

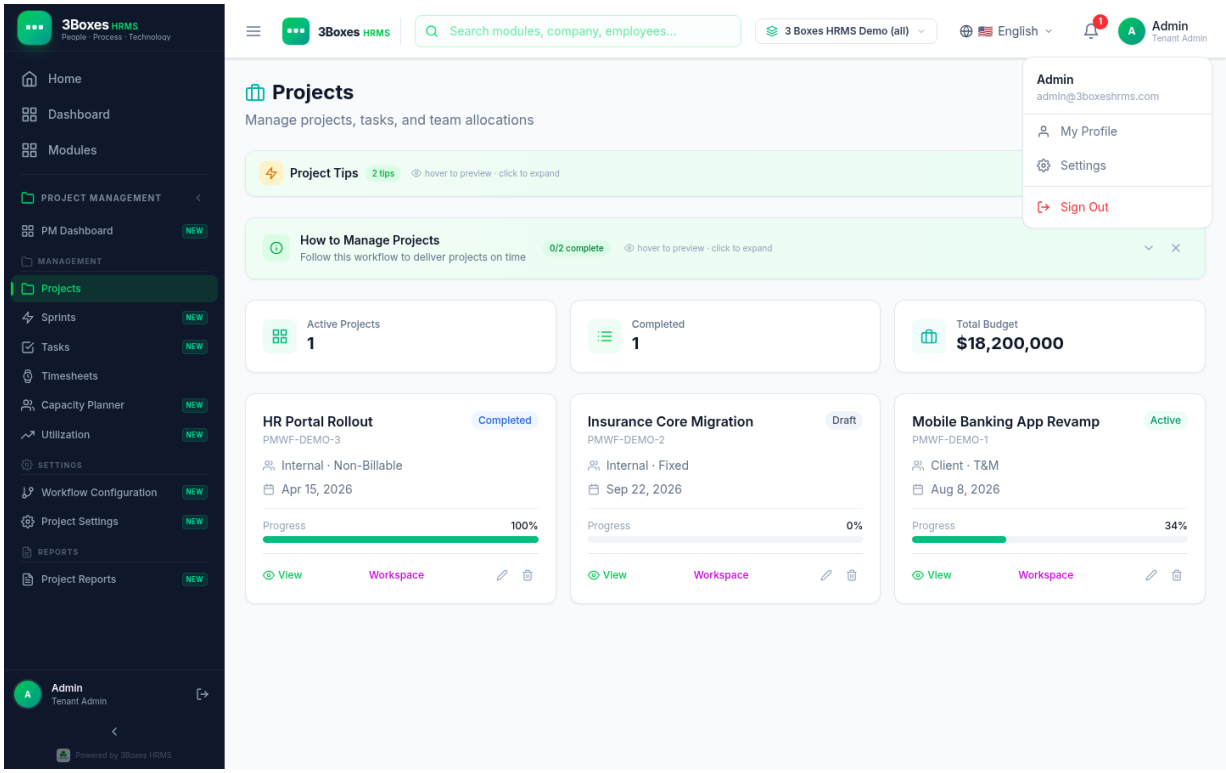


Figure 2-2: The Projects home - portfolio KPIs on top, project cards with status, progress and quick actions below

3. Workflow Configuration (Admin)

This chapter is for Super Admins and Tenant Admins. The Workflow Configuration console is the control room of the module: it defines how projects are approved, how stage gates route, when the system warns about over-allocation, which automation fires on approval, where timesheets route for sign-off, and what evidence closure requires. The console supports two scopes: **Tenant-wide (all companies)** and **company-scoped**. A company-scoped configuration always overrides the tenant-wide default for projects belonging to that company; where a company has no configuration, the tenant default applies, and where neither exists the platform defaults apply.

```
NAVIGATION: Sidebar / Workflow Configuration (under Project Management)
```

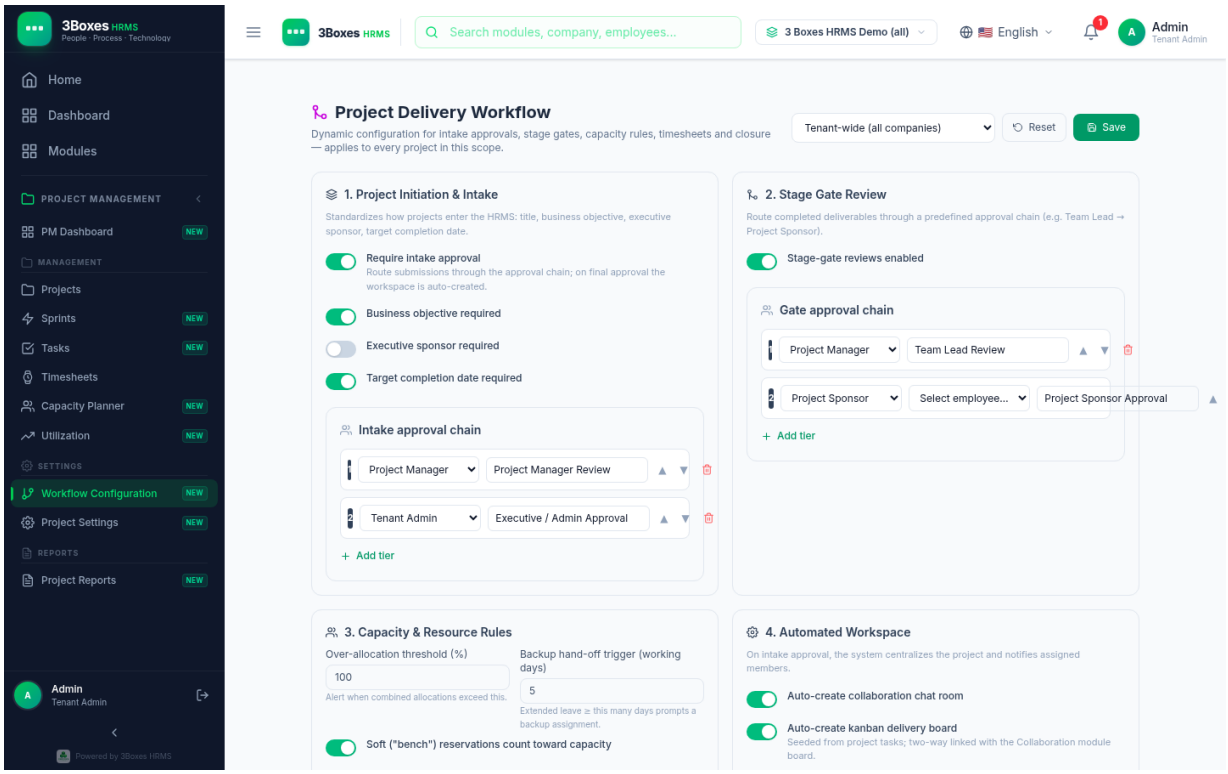


Figure 3-1: The Workflow Configuration console - six governed sections with tenant-wide or company scope

3.1 Section 1 - Project Initiation and Intake

This section decides what a complete intake looks like. Toggles control whether the business objective, the executive sponsor and the target completion date are mandatory fields on the intake form; the delivery methodology is always mandatory. Below the toggles sits the **intake approval chain builder**. Each tier is a row with three parts: the approver source (for example Project Manager, Team Lead, Tenant Admin, or a named employee), a display label such as "Project Manager Review", and reorder plus delete controls. Tiers are executed strictly in order - tier 2 is only notified after tier 1 approves - and the project becomes active the moment the final tier approves.

1. Open Workflow Configuration and choose the scope (Tenant-wide or a specific company).
2. In Section 1, switch on the fields your governance requires: business objective, executive sponsor, target completion date.
3. In the Intake approval chain, set tier 1 (commonly Project Manager - "Project Manager Review") and tier 2 (commonly Tenant Admin - "Executive / Admin Approval").
4. Add further tiers with + Add tier if your process needs finance or PMO review; use the arrow buttons to order them.
5. Press Save. New submissions immediately follow the new chain; projects already in flight keep the chain they were submitted under.

3.2 Section 2 - Stage Gate Review

Stage gates route completed deliverables - and in Waterfall projects, phase completions - through a review chain before they count as accepted. Enable the toggle to activate gate reviews, then build the **gate approval chain** exactly like the intake chain. The recommended pattern is two tiers: a Project Manager or Team Lead tier labelled "Team Lead Review", followed by a Project Sponsor tier labelled "Project Sponsor Approval". The sponsor tier is what stamps the milestone with its approval status and actual date, so place the most senior accountable person last. Gates are per-project and per-deliverable: a gate decision applies to the submission at hand, not to the whole project.

3.3 Section 3 - Capacity and Resource Rules

Three controls govern resourcing safety. The **over-allocation threshold** (default 100 percent) determines when the capacity planner raises an alert: any employee whose combined confirmed plus soft allocations exceed the threshold in a week is flagged in red with the exact percentage and week. The **backup hand-off trigger** (default 5 working days) watches approved leave: when an allocated team member has an approved absence at least this long, the system notifies the PMs of every active project the person is allocated to, prompting a backup assignment. The **soft ("bench") reservations** toggle decides whether soft reservations count toward capacity while they wait for confirmation - keeping it on is recommended, because it is exactly what prevents two PMs from reserving the same bench person.

> **Threshold discipline**
>
> Raising the over-allocation threshold above 100 silences the warning but does not create capacity - the person still has a finite week. Keep 100 as the alert level and treat any red cell in the planner as a scheduling defect to fix, not noise to tune away.

3.4 Section 4 - Automated Workspace

On final intake approval the platform can assemble the project workspace automatically. The **auto-create collaboration chat room** toggle opens a dedicated project chat room; the **auto-create kanban delivery board** toggle creates a delivery board seeded from the project tasks, with every card two-way linked to its

task record. Both surfaces live in the Collaboration module and are linked from the project workspace. Member notifications are always sent on approval. Disabling the toggles does not affect existing projects - automation runs once, at the moment of final approval.

3.5 Section 5 - Timesheet Routing

This section decides who approves billable time. The default routing chain is: the approver named on the employee's project allocation first; if none is set, the project's Project Manager; and as a last resort the submission is routed to the admin queue with a notification. The routing applies to every timesheet row submitted against the project. In Waterfall projects an additional hard rule applies regardless of routing: time cannot be logged against a task whose phase has not been approved yet - the submission is rejected with a clear phase-gate message naming the blocking phase.

3.6 Section 6 - Closure Checklist and Sprint Defaults

Closure is evidence-driven. The checklist section defines which items the readiness report demands before the sign-off button becomes available - typical items are all stage gates approved, milestones stamped, timesheets fully approved and the post-mortem completed per allocated member. Sprint defaults set the organisation's standard sprint length in weeks, which pre-fills new sprints on Agile projects. As everywhere in the console, Save applies the configuration to the selected scope only, and Reset restores the platform defaults for that scope.

> **Pilot per company**
> Introduce stricter chains by scoping them to a pilot company first. Company scope overrides tenant defaults, so you can trial a three-tier intake for one subsidiary and promote it tenant-wide once the process has proven itself.

4. Stage 1 - Project Initiation and Intake

4.1 Creating a New Project

A project begins life as an intake submission. Any Project Manager (or admin) opens the intake form from the Projects page; the Create Project button is top right. The form is intentionally short but governed: the fields your administrator marked mandatory in Workflow Configuration carry live validation, and the submission cannot leave the draft state until they are satisfied. Fields not marked mandatory can be completed later from the same form.

```
NAVIGATION: Sidebar / Projects / + Create Project
```

Field	Required	Purpose
Project title	Always	Short, recognisable name shown on cards, boards and reports
Business objective	Configurable	The measurable outcome, e.g. "Lift mobile NPS by 20 points"
Executive sponsor	Configurable	The accountable senior owner; typically the final intake approver
Target completion date	Configurable	Drives milestone variance and closure readiness
Delivery methodology	Always	Agile / Scrum or Waterfall - selects the planning toolkit
Cost center / internal code	Optional	Finance tagging for budgets and invoices
Travel / contractor budget	Optional	Links the project to the travel desk and expense budget

Table 4-1: Intake form fields

4.2 Choosing the Methodology

The methodology selector at the top of the form is the single most consequential choice on the page. Choose **Agile / Scrum** when scope is expected to evolve and the team can work in sprint rhythms; the project workspace will offer sprint creation, story points, velocity and burndown. Choose **Waterfall** when scope and dates are contractual; the workspace will offer phases, milestone sequencing, budget caps and the phase-gate time-logging rule. The selector also drives the timesheet experience: Agile users see their active sprint pre-selected when logging time, while Waterfall users see the current phase badge and are blocked from unapproved phases.

4.3 Submitting for Approval

Pressing Submit does three things. It validates the mandatory fields against the active configuration; it snapshots the approval chain from the configuration so later config changes do not disturb in-flight projects; and it notifies the first-tier approver with a direct link to the request. The project card now shows intake status "Submitted" and the Overview tab displays the chain with each tier's live status. The project is visible to admins but is not yet an active delivery - no workspace exists and no time can be logged.

1. Complete every mandatory field; attach cost center and travel budget if applicable.
2. Select the methodology and double-check the target completion date.
3. Press Submit - the first approver is notified immediately.
4. Watch the Intake approval chain panel on the Overview tab for tier-by-tier progress.

4.4 Approving or Rejecting Intake

Approvers act from the project's Overview and Intake tab or from the notification link. The chain panel shows every tier, its approver source and its current status; the tier awaiting your decision is highlighted as actionable. Approving a non-final tier simply advances the chain and notifies the next approver. Approving the **final** tier triggers the activation sequence described below. Rejecting any tier returns the project to its

author with the decision recorded in the approval trail; the PM can revise the intake and resubmit, which starts the chain again from tier 1.

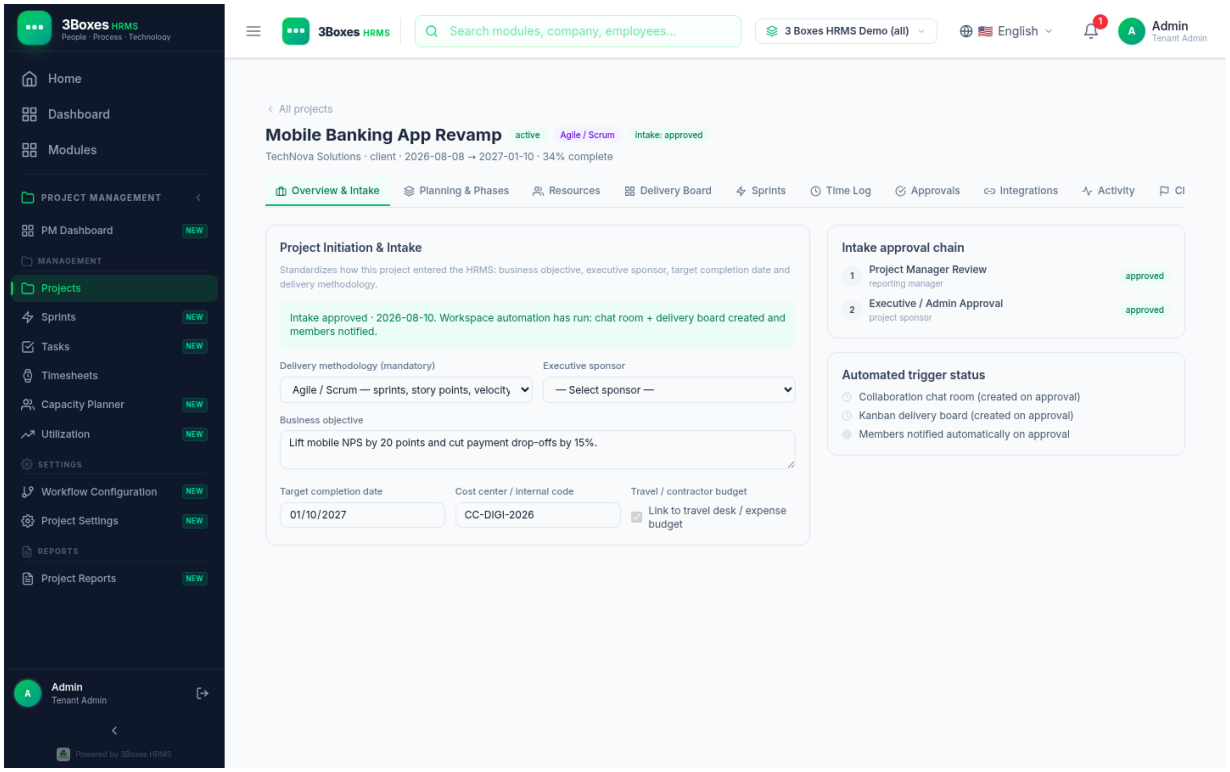


Figure 4-1: The Overview and Intake tab - approval chain with per-tier status and the automated trigger checklist

4.5 What Happens on Final Approval

Final approval is the automated trigger point. The system performs, in order: the project status flips to Active; the collaboration chat room is created (if enabled); the kanban delivery board is created and seeded from the project's tasks with two-way card links (if enabled); every member listed on the project receives a notification; and the intake banner switches to the green "approved" state recording the approval date. From this moment the workspace tabs - Planning, Resources, Delivery Board, Sprints, Time Log - are fully live.

> **If automation is disabled**
>
> When your administrator has switched off workspace automation, final approval still activates the project, but the chat room and board must be created manually from the Collaboration module and linked from the project workspace. The Automated trigger status panel on the Overview tab shows exactly which pieces exist.

5. Stage 2 - Planning and Resource Management

Planning turns an approved project into a staffed, scheduled and budgeted plan. Everything in this chapter happens inside the project workspace, on the Planning and Phases, Resources and Sprints tabs, and in the standalone Capacity Planner. The golden rule of this stage: no person should ever be committed above the over-allocation threshold, and every commitment should start as a soft reservation until confirmed with the employee's manager.

5.1 Raising a Role Requirement

On the Resources tab the PM describes **what** is needed before caring about **who**. A role requirement is a structured request: role title (for example Senior Backend Developer), seniority, headcount (for example 2 positions), the must-have skills with proficiency, the weekly allocation percentage, and the start date. Requirements are visible on the project and drive the matchmaking engine; they also give leadership a clean view of unfilled demand across the portfolio.

```
NAVIGATION: Projects / (project) / Resources / New role requirement
```

5.2 Skill Matchmaking

Pressing Run matchmaking asks the platform to score every employee against the requirement. The score out of 100 weighs three signals: skill fit (about 60 percent - matched skills and proficiency against the requirement), available capacity (about 25 percent - contracted hours minus confirmed and soft allocations, approved leave and holidays in the requested window), and context (about 15 percent - factors such as current utilisation and role relevance). If the strict skill filter would return nobody, the engine falls back to the general bench pool and says so, so a PM is never left with an empty list. Candidates are listed best-first with their score breakdown.

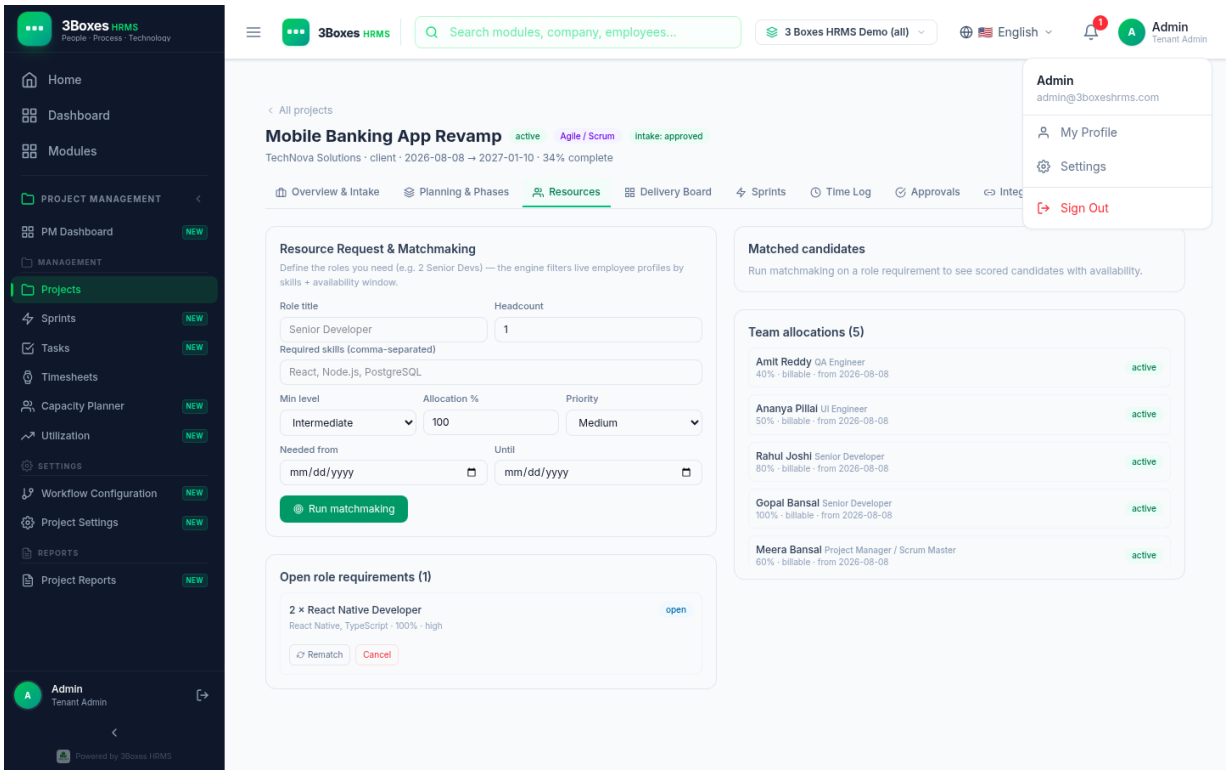


Figure 5-1: The Resources tab - role requirement, ranked matchmaking candidates with scores, and current allocations

5.3 Soft Allocation - Reserving from the Bench

Choosing Soft reserve places the candidate on the project as a **soft allocation**: the person is marked as pencilled-in, the reservation immediately counts toward their weekly capacity (when the bench toggle is on), and the capacity planner shows the soft overlay. Nothing is asked of the employee yet. This is the mechanism that stops the classic double-booking failure - a second PM running matchmaking over the same week will see the capacity already consumed. Soft allocations appear on the employee's availability calendar and can be released with one click if plans change.

1. Review the ranked candidates; open a profile to check skills evidence and current projects.
2. Press Soft reserve on the chosen candidate(s) - capacity is blocked instantly.
3. Coordinate with the employee's reporting manager to confirm release.
4. Press Confirm allocation (or Allocate) to convert soft to confirmed.

5.4 Confirming the Team

Confirming an allocation does three things at once: the allocation becomes active on the project, the employee is added as a project member with the appropriate project role (which gates what they can do in the workspace), and a notification goes to the employee with the project, role and start date. Only confirmed members appear by default in task assignee pickers and sprint pods. The allocations list on the Resources tab shows every member, their allocation percentage, status (soft or confirmed) and the linked approver used for timesheet routing.

> **Over-allocation is checked at commit time**
>
> The system refuses a confirmation that would push the employee past the over-allocation threshold for any week in the allocation window. The rejection names the week and the conflicting project. Releasing or shortening the other allocation is the intended fix - not silencing the alert.

5.5 The Capacity Planner

The Capacity Planner is the portfolio-wide lens on the same data. Pick an employee chip (or scan the grid) to see a week-by-week view for the selected horizon (default six weeks): each cell shows utilisation percent and hours, with soft allocations, approved leave day ranges and company holidays overlaid. Over-allocation alerts are collected at the top with the exact weeks and the threshold that fired. The planner also offers an assignment pre-check: before confirming an allocation, ask the planner whether the added load would breach the threshold, and record a backup acknowledge when a counterparty accepts overflow risk.

```
NAVIGATION: Sidebar / Capacity Planner
```

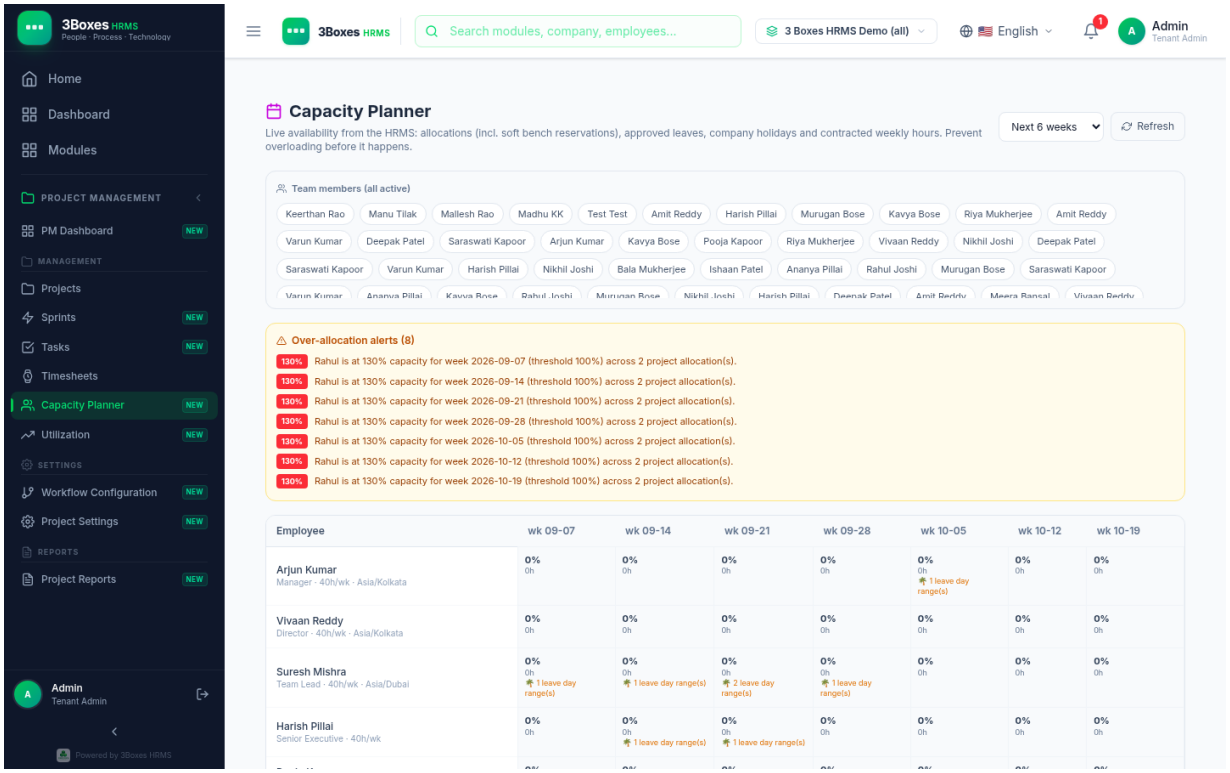


Figure 5-2: Capacity Planner - over-allocation alerts on top, weekly utilisation grid with leave and holiday overlays below

5.6 Phases and Milestones (Waterfall)

On the Planning and Phases tab a Waterfall PM builds the phase skeleton: phases are created in delivery order, each with a sequence number, target dates and an optional budget cap. Milestones anchor the plan - give each a name, a due date and its phase. Two rules are enforced. First, phase gates: a phase's tasks cannot consume logged time until the preceding phase has passed its stage-gate approval. Second, budget caps: when

logged-time cost (computed from decrypted employee cost rates) approaches or exceeds a phase's cap, the readiness report and dashboard surface the slippage so it is caught mid-flight, not at closure.

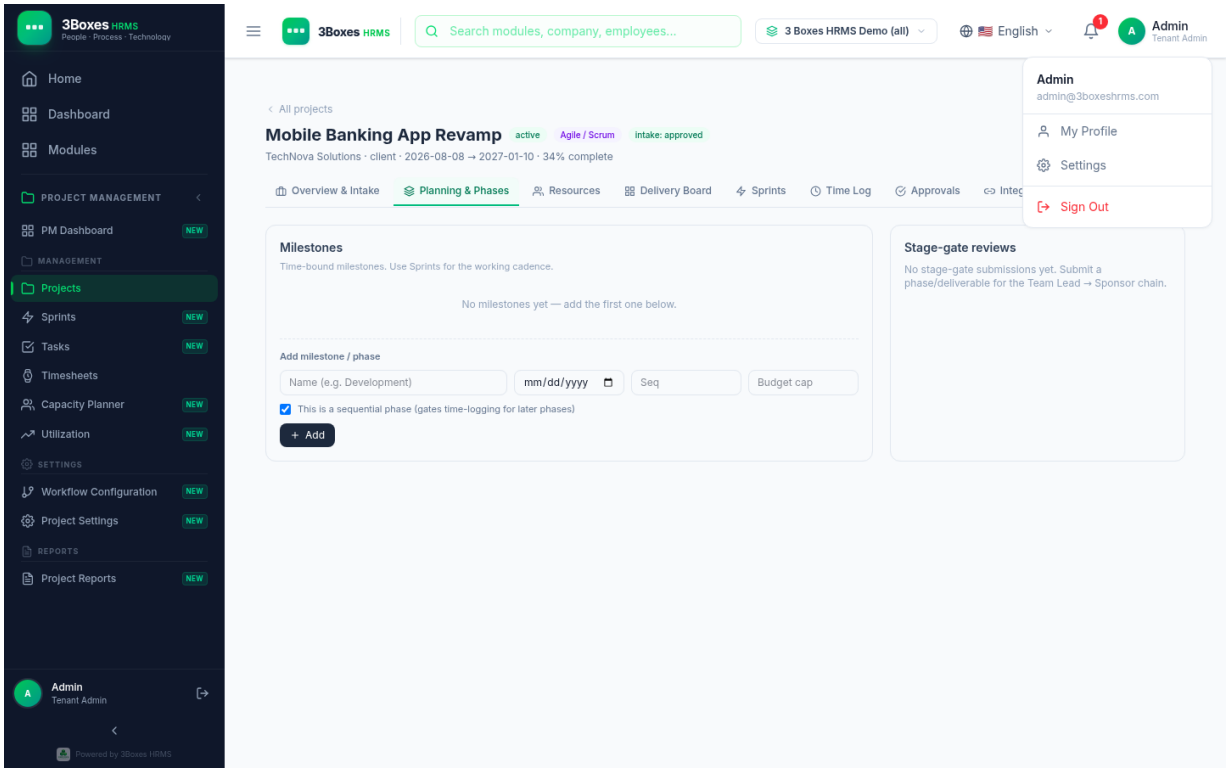


Figure 5-3: Planning and Phases tab - phase list with sequence and budget caps, milestone mapping

5.7 Sprint Setup (Agile)

For Agile projects the same tab lists sprints. Create sprints with the organisation's standard duration (from workflow configuration), name them by outcome, and move planned story-pointed tasks in. Committed points are tallied automatically as tasks are assigned to the sprint. The delivery rhythm itself - starting, completing and the one-active-sprint lock - is described in Chapter 6.

> **Plan the pod, not just the backlog**
>
> A sprint should never commit more points than the pod's demonstrated velocity. Check the velocity bars on the Sprints tab (completed versus committed per sprint) before locking the next sprint's scope.

6. Stage 3 - Execution and Delivery

Execution is where the plan meets the week. The delivery board is the operational surface, sprints are the heartbeat for Agile teams, phases advance the Waterfall critical path, timesheets convert effort into billable truth, and integrations keep external tooling in step. Every screen in this chapter is reachable from the project workspace tabs, and every state change persists immediately - nothing on the board is cosmetic.

6.1 Tasks - Creating, Assigning and Gating

Tasks are the atomic unit of delivery. Create them from the Delivery Board's "+ New task" button or the Tasks page. Beyond a title and description, a task can carry: an assignee (from confirmed project members), a sprint (Agile), a phase (Waterfall), story points (Agile sizing), a priority, and a **depends-on** task modelling a finish-to-start constraint. Dependencies are enforced: attempting to move a task to In Progress or Done while its blocker is incomplete is rejected with a message naming the blocker, and circular dependencies are refused at save time. Editing a task is possible at any time from the card's menu; deleting a task that already has logged time performs a soft-cancel that preserves the timesheet history for billing while removing the task from active boards.

6.2 The Delivery Board

The Delivery Board is a four-column kanban - To Do, In Progress, Review, Done - with drag-and-drop that persists the status change the moment a card lands. Cards show their story points, sprint badge, priority chip, assignee avatar and a dependency chip: green when the blocker is complete, amber marked "(gate)" when the way is still blocked. Two-way synchronisation is built in: moving a card updates the linked card on the project's Collaboration kanban board, and a move made on the Collaboration board updates the task here, including stamping completedAt when a card reaches Done. The board caption reminds everyone of this link.

```
NAVIGATION: Projects / (project) / Delivery Board
```

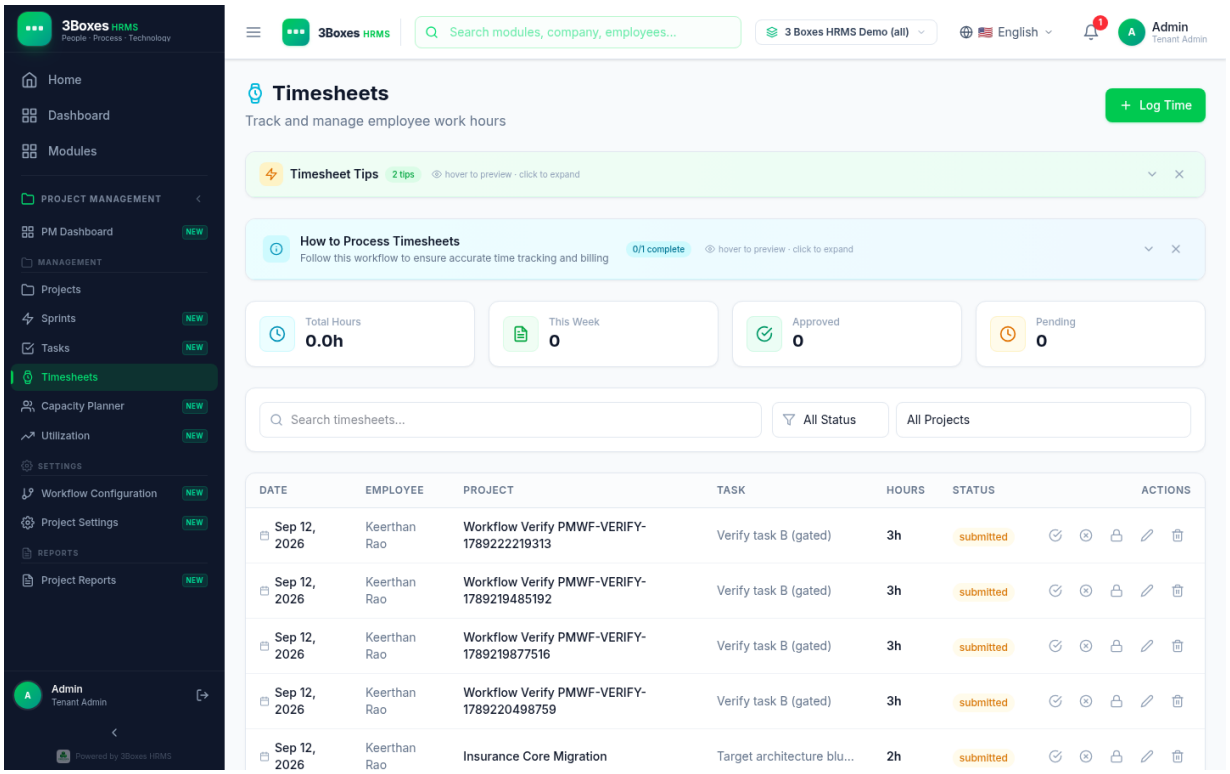


Figure 6-1: The Delivery Board - kanban columns with story points, sprint badges and a dependency chip on "Fraud rule engine integration"

6.3 Running Sprints (Agile)

Sprints have three states: Planned, Active and Completed. Pressing Start on a planned sprint activates it and enforces the **one-active-sprint rule** per project pod - a second sprint cannot start until the active one is completed, which keeps the team's focus and the burndown honest. Starting also snapshots the committed points for the say-do calculation. Pressing Complete sweeps any unfinished stories to the backlog (or the next sprint if one is planned), then computes the sprint's scorecard: velocity (points actually completed), the say-do ratio (completed over committed - 100 percent means the sprint delivered exactly what it promised) and the burndown shape. The Sprints tab shows these bars across all sprints so trend degradation is visible at a glance.

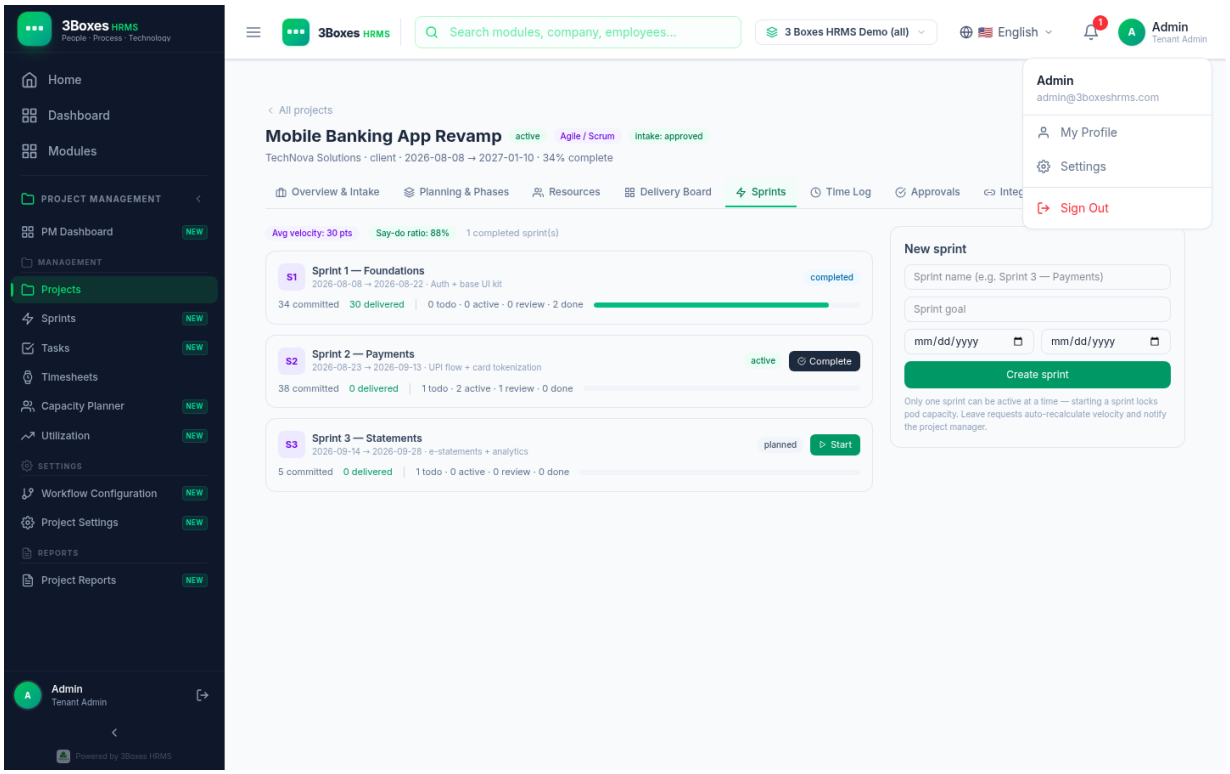


Figure 6-2: The Sprints tab - committed versus completed velocity bars, say-do ratio and sprint states

> **Leave changes velocity - automatically**
>
> When an allocated member's leave is approved mid-sprint, the sprint's expected capacity is recalculated and the Scrum Master (PM) is notified. The say-do ratio you report at sprint review therefore already reflects the absence - no manual adjustment needed.

6.4 Phases in Execution (Waterfall)

Waterfall execution is phase-driven. Work the current phase's tasks on the same delivery board; the phase badge on each task shows where it belongs. The control comes at the boundary: when a phase's deliverables are complete, the PM submits a stage-gate review (Chapter 7). Until that gate is approved, the platform refuses timesheet rows against the **next** phase's tasks - the rejection names the unapproved phase, so finance never sees effort booked ahead of acceptance.

6.5 Timesheets

Timesheets turn worked hours into billable, approvable records. Employees log time from the Timesheets page or the project's Time Log tab: pick the date, the project, the task (a quick-pick dropdown pre-fills your assigned tasks, badge-tagged with the active sprint or phase), the hours, and the billable status. The unified record - Employee, Project, Date, Hours, Billable - is what the rest of the platform bills and reports from. Weekly views aggregate the days for review before submission. Every row enters the approval chain defined in workflow configuration: the allocation's approver first, the project PM as fallback, and admin queue as the last resort. Approvers act from the Timesheets page where pending rows show approve, reject and lock actions.

```
NAVIGATION: Sidebar / Timesheets (or) Projects / (project) / Time Log
```

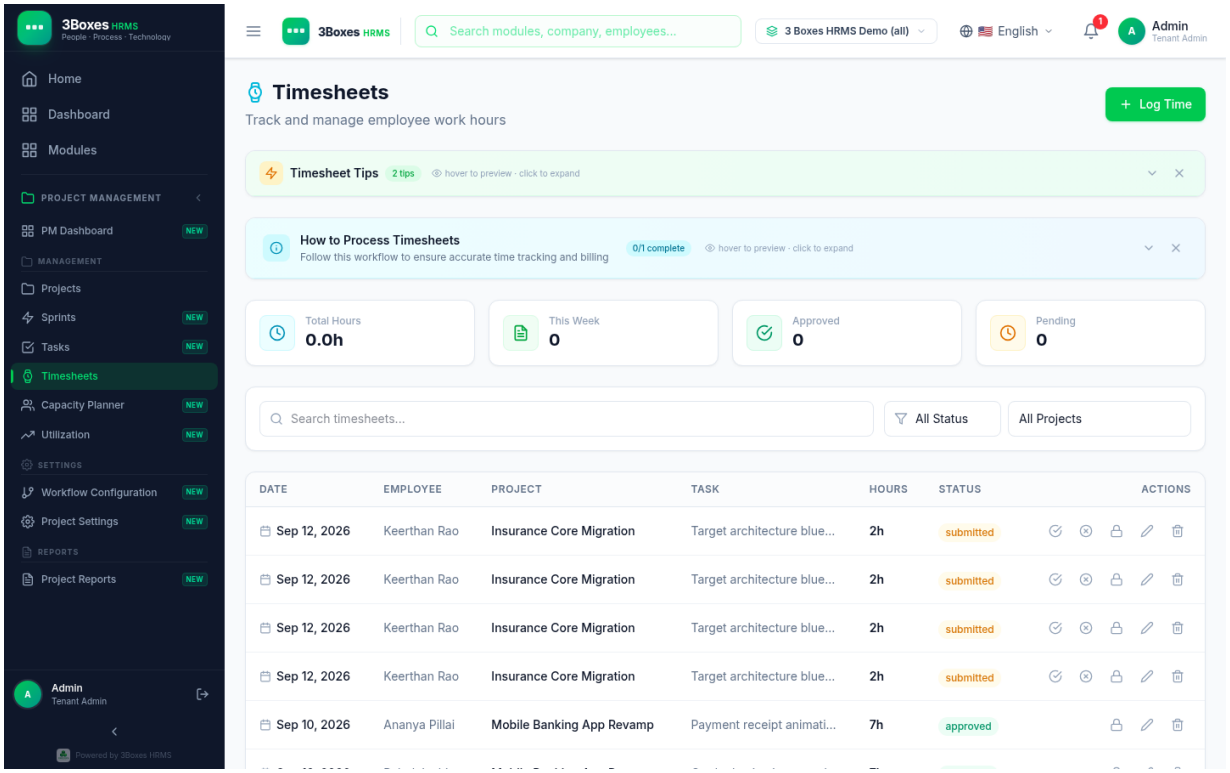


Figure 6-3: The Timesheets page - KPI strip, filters, and the approval worklist with per-row actions

> **Billable discipline**
>
> Billable status is a financial declaration, not a note. Rows marked billable flow to invoicing views; rows marked non-billable are cost-only. When in doubt, mark the row billable and let the approver correct it - wrongly non-billable rows silently leak revenue.

6.6 Activity Feed and Collaboration

The Activity tab is the project's audit trail and social surface: intake decisions, workspace automation events, allocation changes, sprint transitions, gate decisions and integrations events are logged automatically with actor and timestamp, interleaved with member status updates. The auto-created chat room carries day-to-day discussion, and the Collaboration kanban board mirrors task state as described above. Keeping substantive decisions in the feed (rather than only in chat) is what makes closure and audits painless.

6.7 Third-Party Integrations - Jira and Azure DevOps

The Integrations tab connects the project to Jira Cloud or Azure DevOps. Connecting requires the site or organisation URL, a user identifier and an API token; the platform immediately **tests the credentials** before storing them, and stores the token encrypted (AES-256-GCM). Once connected, three flows are available: **import** pulls external issues into the project as tasks (with a field mapping for status and type), **push** sends project tasks outward as issues, and **status sync** propagates transitions both ways according to a configurable

status mapping, so "Done on the delivery board" can mean "Resolved in Jira". The sync status panel shows the last import, last push and any errors.

```
NAVIGATION: Projects / (project) / Integrations
```

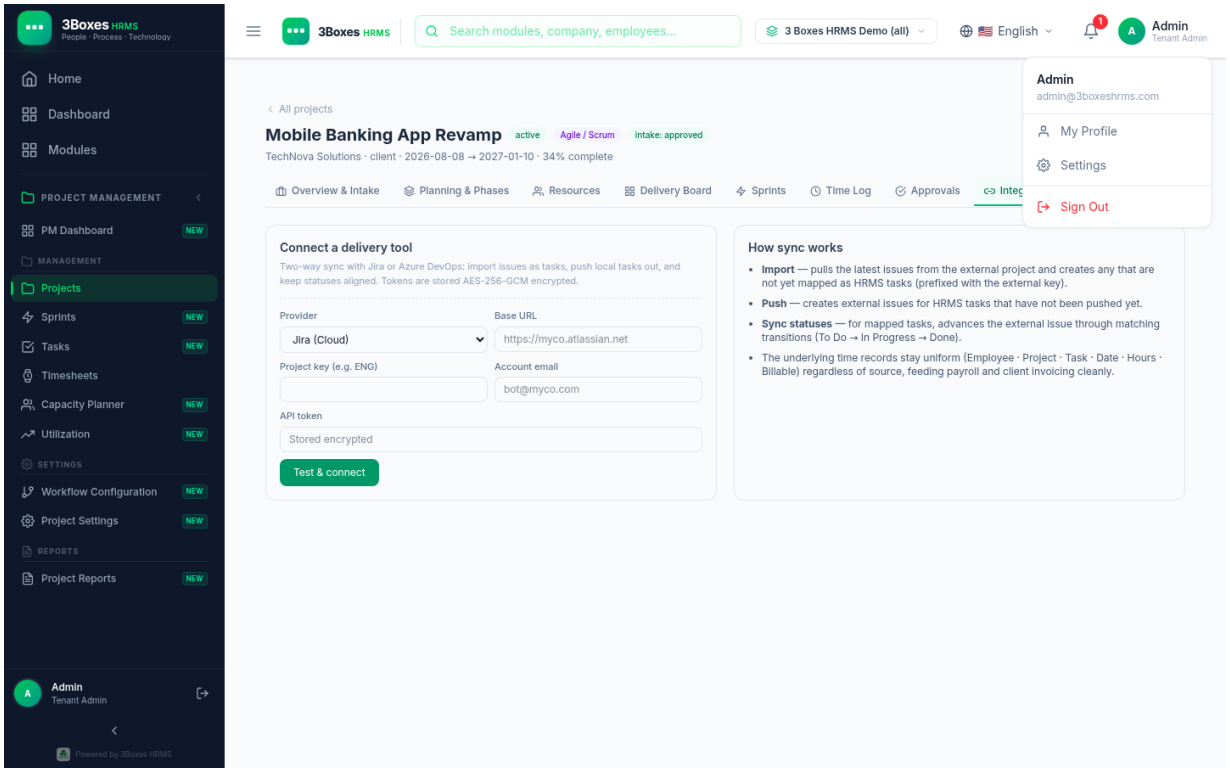


Figure 6-4: The Integrations tab - provider connect cards, credential test on connect, import and push actions with sync status

> **Integration hygiene**
>
> Import once to seed, then let status sync carry the load. Re-importing the same issues creates duplicates; if a mapping goes wrong, fix the status mapping JSON and use the sync-status panel to verify before pushing again.

7. Stage 4 - Review and Stage-Gate Approvals

Stage gates are the quality checkpoint between doing the work and accepting it. A gate is a formal review of a deliverable - or a completed Waterfall phase - routed through the approval chain defined in workflow configuration, typically a Team Lead tier followed by the Project Sponsor. Gates protect the sponsor's accountability, create a dated acceptance record for every major deliverable, and in Waterfall projects unlock the next phase for time logging. Until the final gate tier approves, the deliverable formally remains "in review" regardless of how finished it feels.

7.1 Submitting a Stage-Gate Review (PM)

When a deliverable or phase is ready, the Project Manager opens the Approvals tab and submits a gate review. The submission bundles the evidence the chain needs: the deliverable or phase reference, the

milestone it satisfies, completion notes and links to the underlying tasks with their logged hours. The first tier in the gate chain is notified immediately, and the submission appears in the Approvals tab with its per-tier status.

```
NAVIGATION: Projects / (project) / Approvals / Submit stage-gate review
```

1. Confirm the deliverable's tasks are Done and timesheets against them are submitted.
2. Open Approvals and press Submit stage-gate review; pick the deliverable or phase and the milestone it closes.
3. Write completion notes the sponsor can actually rely on - scope covered, tests or acceptance evidence, known gaps.
4. Submit. Tier 1 of the gate chain is notified; track progress in the Approvals tab.

7.2 The Team Lead to Sponsor Chain

The chain executes tier by tier, strictly in order. The Team Lead (or first tier) reviews the engineering reality - are the tasks genuinely done, is the work quality acceptable - and approves or rejects with comments. Approval advances the chain and notifies the next tier. The Project Sponsor reviews at the acceptance level - does this satisfy the business objective - and their approval is the consequential one: on the final tier's approval the platform stamps the linked milestone as approved with its actual date, which is precisely what closure later reads. A rejection at any tier returns the submission to the PM with the reviewer's comments; rework happens in Stage 3 and the gate is resubmitted from scratch.

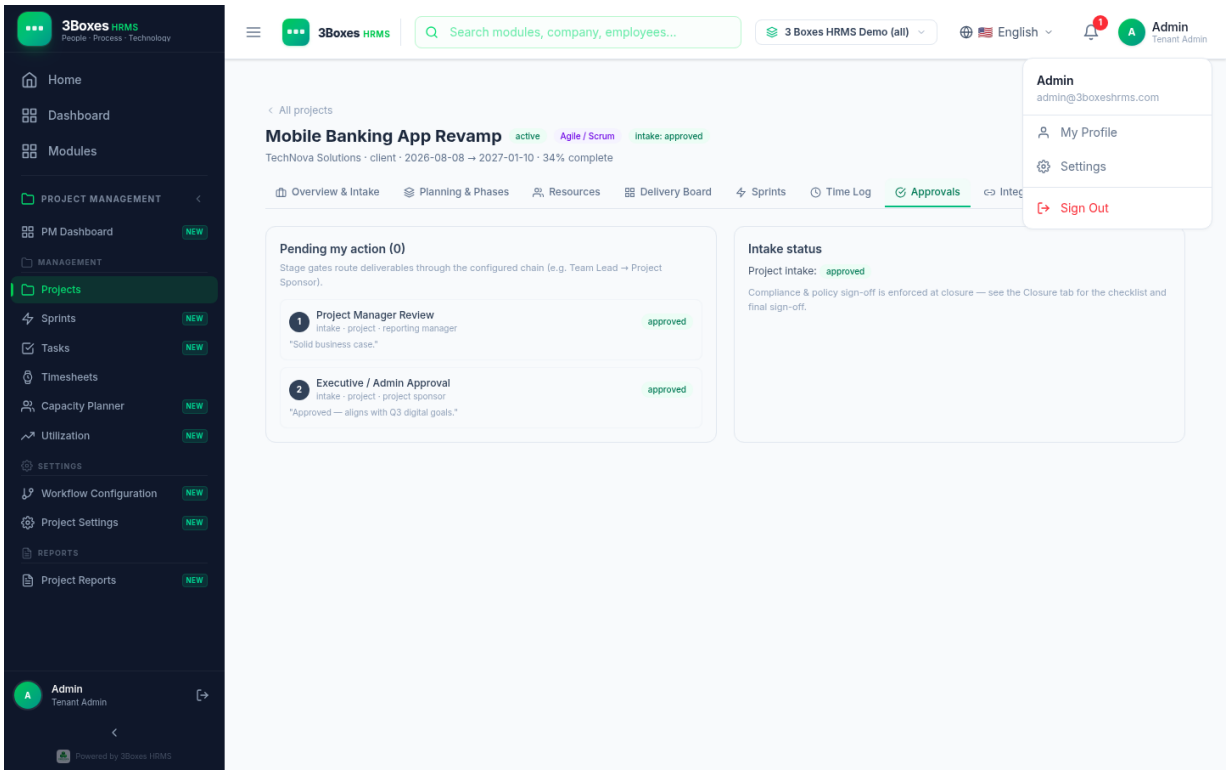


Figure 7-1: The Approvals tab - gate submissions with per-tier status; your actionable tiers are highlighted

7.3 What Approvers See and Do

Approvers act from the Approvals tab or the notification link. Tiers where you are the current decision-maker are visually highlighted as actionable; tiers where you already decided show the decision and date. Decisions are final for that submission round - there is no recall, only a new submission after rework. Everything (who decided, when, with what comments) is preserved in the project's approval trail on the Activity feed, which is what auditors and the closure readiness report read.

> **Gate approvals unlock Waterfall phases**
> In Waterfall projects, the gate approval that closes Phase N is also the key that unlocks Phase N+1 for time logging. If your team reports "cannot log time" on a new phase, check whether the previous phase's gate is still pending before assuming a system fault.

8. Stage 5 - Closure and Post-Mortem

Closure is a controlled landing, not an off switch. The Closure tab computes a live readiness report, collects the post-mortem that feeds the Performance module, and only then allows the compliance sign-off that formally closes the project - sealing allocations, archiving boards and fixing the final financial picture. A project that cannot show its evidence stays open.

8.1 The Closure Readiness Report

The readiness report is generated from live data the moment you open the Closure tab. It states, without anyone hand-compiling it: total hours logged on the project; actual cost computed from employee cost rates (stored encrypted and decrypted only for authorised viewers); budget variance against the project budget and per-phase caps; milestone variance - what percentage of milestones hit their approved dates; task statistics (completed versus cancelled versus open); and open compliance items from the closure checklist. Each item is present or outstanding, so the gap to closure is always a list, never a mystery.

```
NAVIGATION: Projects / (project) / Closure
```

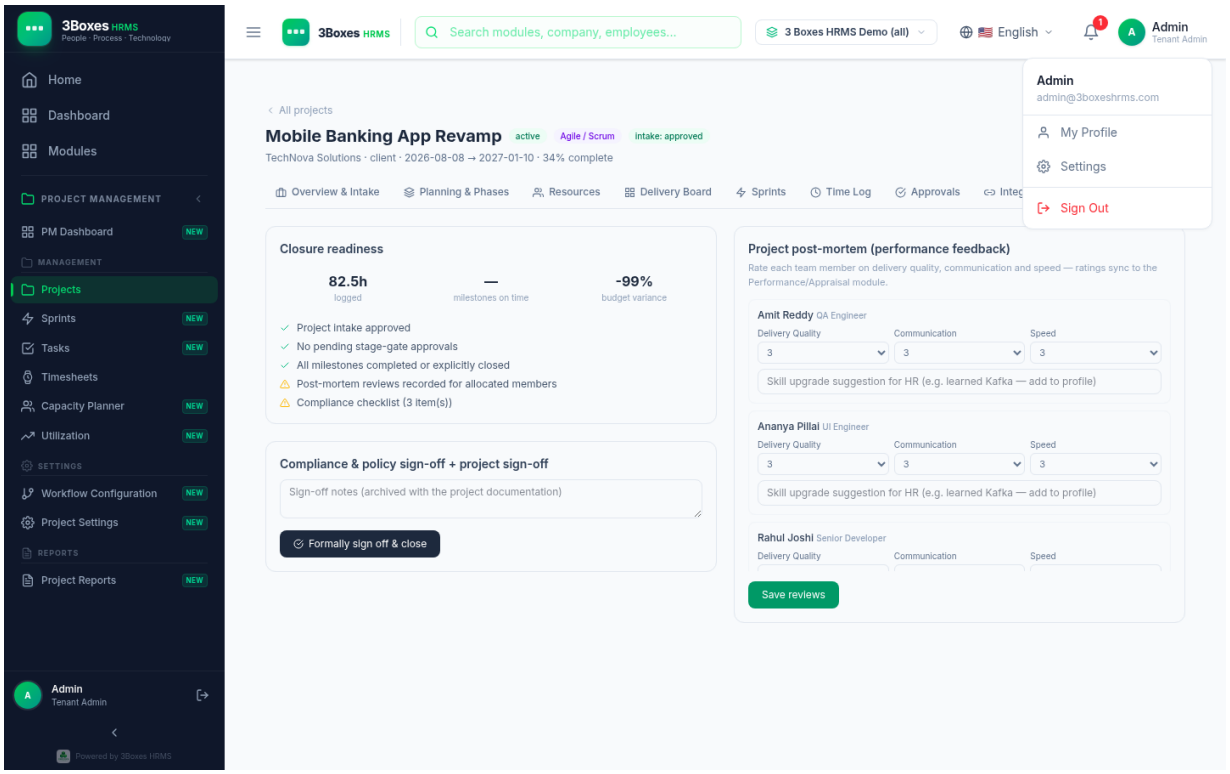


Figure 8-1: The Closure tab - readiness metrics, post-mortem editor and compliance sign-off

8.2 Post-Mortem Reviews and Performance Feedback

Before sign-off, every confirmed project member is rated on the post-mortem form across three dimensions: delivery quality, communication and speed, each on a simple rating scale, plus a free-text contribution note. Separately, the PM records skill upgrade suggestions - "Priya should add Terraform to her master skill list" - which notify HR to update the employee's skill inventory so future matchmaking benefits. The contribution metrics and ratings synchronise to the Performance module, where they become evidence in the employee's annual appraisal cycle. This is the loop that makes project history compound: today's delivery data is tomorrow's matching, staffing and appraisal input.

1. Open the post-mortem panel on the Closure tab.
2. Rate each confirmed member on delivery quality, communication and speed; add a one-line contribution note.
3. Record skill upgrade suggestions where the project revealed new capabilities.
4. Submit the post-mortem - HR is notified of skill suggestions immediately.

8.3 Compliance Checklist and Sign-off

The compliance checklist (defined by your administrators in workflow configuration) enumerates what "done" means: typically all stage gates approved, all milestones stamped, timesheets fully approved and no pending submissions, the post-mortem complete for every member, and budget variance acknowledged. The sign-off button activates only when the checklist is satisfied and the readiness report shows no outstanding

items. Signing off requires the authority of a Tenant Admin or the executive sponsor; the signer's name and the closure date are stamped permanently on the project.

> **Sign-off is final**
> Closure seals the project: allocations are closed, the board is archived read-only, and no further timesheet rows are accepted against it. If any billing reconciliation is outstanding, complete it before signing - reopening a closed project requires an administrator and is discouraged.

8.4 After Closure

A closed project remains fully readable: the workspace tabs keep their final state, the readiness report freezes as the closure record, and the project card on the Projects page shows the Completed badge with final progress. Its data continues to work - hours feed revenue and utilisation reports, the post-mortem ratings surface in appraisals, skill suggestions refresh the inventory, and the project appears as a reference point in future matchmaking context. The project's collaboration room can be retained or archived by the Collaboration module's own lifecycle rules.

9. Role Quick-Reference Cards

This chapter compresses the manual into four one-page cards. Each card lists the actions a role performs in a typical week, in the order they usually occur, with the navigation path. Hand the relevant card to each persona during onboarding; the full chapters remain the reference for the "why".

9.1 Super Admin / Tenant Admin

When	Action	Navigation
Setup	Configure intake chain, gates, capacity rules, workspace automation, timesheet routing, closure checklist	Workflow Configuration
As needed	Approve intake (final tier), act as executive approver	Projects / (project) / Overview and Intake
Weekly	Review portfolio KPIs and over-allocation alerts	PM Dashboard, Capacity Planner
On sign-off request	Verify readiness report, sign closure	Projects / (project) / Closure
Governance	Audit activity feeds and approval trails	Projects / (project) / Activity

Table 9-1: Administrator weekly rhythm

9.2 Project Manager

When	Action	Navigation
New work	Create project, complete intake, select methodology, submit	Projects / + Create Project
After approval	Raise role requirements, run matchmaking, soft-reserve then confirm team	(project) / Resources
Plan	Create sprints or phases and milestones; set budget caps	(project) / Planning and Phases
Daily	Curate the delivery board; watch dependency and gate chips	(project) / Delivery Board
Sprint cadence	Start and complete sprints; read velocity and say-do	(project) / Sprints
Deliverable ready	Submit stage-gate review with evidence	(project) / Approvals
Phase boundary	Watch phase gates; unblock time logging by gating on time	(project) / Approvals, Time Log
Wind-down	Review readiness report, complete post-mortem, request sign-off	(project) / Closure

Table 9-2: PM weekly rhythm

9.3 Team Lead / Approver

When	Action	Navigation
Intake routing	Review and approve your intake tier when named in the chain	(project) / Overview and Intake
Gate reviews	Verify tasks genuinely Done before approving tier 1	(project) / Approvals
Board hygiene	Review In Progress and Review columns; unblock dependencies	(project) / Delivery Board
Timesheets	Approve or reject submitted rows for your reportees	Timesheets
Capacity	Acknowledge backup requests when releasing people on leave	Capacity Planner

Table 9-3: Team Lead weekly rhythm

9.4 Team Member (Employee)

When	Action	Navigation
Day start	Check assigned tasks and the active sprint or phase	Tasks; (project) / Delivery Board
While working	Move your card across columns; respect dependency chips	(project) / Delivery Board
Daily or weekly	Log time against the right task with correct billable flag	Timesheets / + Log Time
On request	Keep skills profile current so matchmaking stays accurate	My Profile / Skills
Closure	Provide post-mortem inputs when asked	(project) / Closure

Table 9-4: Team member weekly rhythm

10. Approval and Permission Matrix

The matrix below is the authoritative quick answer to "who can do what". It reflects the default configuration; workflow configuration can narrow or widen approval chains, but structural permissions (such as who may edit workflow configuration itself) are fixed by platform role. A bullet marks full permission; a ring marks an action the role participates in conditionally (for example, only when named in the chain or when the action concerns their own record).

Action	Super Admin	Tenant Admin	Project Manager	Team Lead	Team Member
Configure workflows and thresholds	●	● (company scope)	○	○	○
Create project / submit intake	●	●	●	○	○
Approve intake tier	○ (if named)	● (tier-dependent)	○ (tier 1 only)	○ (if named)	○
Raise role requirements / matchmaking	●	●	●	○	○
Soft-reserve and confirm allocations	●	●	●	○	○
Create / edit tasks	●	●	●	●	○ (own cards)
Move cards on delivery board	●	●	●	●	● (assigned)
Start / complete sprints	●	●	●	○	○
Create phases / milestones / budget caps	●	●	●	○	○
Log timesheets	● (own)	● (own)	● (own)	● (own)	● (own)
Approve timesheets	●	●	● (team)	● (team)	○
Submit stage-gate review	●	●	●	○	○

Action	Super Admin	Tenant Admin	Project Manager	Team Lead	Team Member
Decide stage gate	○ (if named)	● (tier-dependent)	○ (tier 1 only)	○ (tier 1 only)	○
Initiate closure / post-mortem	●	●	●	○	○ (input)
Sign closure	●	●	○	○	○
Connect Jira / Azure DevOps	●	●	●	○	○
View encrypted cost rates	●	● (finance role)	○	○	○

Table 10-1: Permission matrix (● = permitted, ○ = conditional or not permitted)

> **Reading the conditions**
>
> Conditional permissions have three patterns: "if named" appears where a specific employee is chosen as an approver tier; "tier 1 only" reflects intake chains whose first tier is the Project Manager role; "own" restricts a member to their own records. Timesheet approval follows the routing chain configured per project.

11. FAQ and Troubleshooting

Most support questions in this module trace back to a governance rule working as designed. The answers below name the rule, explain where the message comes from, and give the shortest path forward. If a symptom is not listed, check the Activity tab first - nearly every automated decision is logged there with its reason.

Q1. Why can I not log time on my Waterfall task?

The phase gate is closed: the task belongs to a phase whose predecessor has not passed stage-gate approval. The rejection message names the blocking phase. The fix is procedural, not technical - have the PM submit (or chase) the previous phase's gate review; approval unlocks logging immediately.

Q2. Why can I not start the next sprint?

The one-active-sprint rule is in force: a project pod runs exactly one active sprint. Complete the current sprint on the Sprints tab (unfinished stories sweep to the backlog or the next sprint automatically), then start the next one.

Q3. My card will not move to In Progress - the drag snaps back or shows a warning. Why?

The task has an unfinished dependency. The dependency chip on the card is amber and marked "(gate)" while the blocker is open. Finish the blocker task (or edit the task to remove the depends-on link if the constraint no longer applies), then move the card.

Q4. Matchmaking returned few or weak candidates. What now?

The engine scored your requirement against real skills and live availability. Widen the requirement (drop one must-have skill, widen the start window), or check the Capacity Planner - if the right people are at or above the over-allocation threshold, no scoring can conjure capacity. When the strict skill pool is empty the engine says it fell back to the general bench pool; treat those results as "nearest available", not "best skilled".

Q5. Who approves my timesheet, and why did it go to the "wrong" person?

Routing follows the configured chain: the approver on your project allocation first, the project's PM as fallback, the admin queue as last resort. If your allocation's approver field is empty or stale, the PM receives it. Ask your PM to set the allocation approver correctly - future rows then route automatically.

Q6. Submitting intake keeps failing validation. What is missing?

The intake validator enforces exactly what your administrators marked mandatory in workflow configuration - commonly the business objective, the executive sponsor or the target completion date. The inline message names the field. Admins can also see the toggles in Section 1 of Workflow Configuration.

Q7. The project was approved - where is the chat room and board?

Workspace automation runs on final approval if enabled. Check the "Automated trigger status" panel on the Overview tab: it lists the chat room, the delivery board and member notifications with their created state. If your tenant disabled automation, create the surfaces manually in the Collaboration module and link them from the workspace.

Q8. Why is someone flagged at 130 percent in the Capacity Planner?

Their confirmed plus soft allocations across projects exceed the configured threshold (default 100 percent) for those weeks. Open the employee chip to see the two competing allocations; release one, shorten it, or - in genuine emergencies - have an admin raise the threshold, knowing the alert will then stay quiet at your peril.

Q9. Leave was approved - why are project managers suddenly notified?

The backup hand-off rule fired: an allocated member's approved absence reached the configured trigger (default five working days), so PMs of the member's active projects are asked to arrange cover. Assign or soft-reserve a backup; the planner's pre-check helps confirm the backup has room.

Q10. What is the difference between a soft and a confirmed allocation?

Soft is a bench reservation: it blocks the person's capacity and appears on their calendar but commits nobody. Confirmed activates the membership with project role and notifications, adds them to assignee pickers, and routes their timesheets. Convert soft to confirmed through the Resources tab once the reporting manager releases the person.

Q11. Can I delete a task that already has logged hours?

Deleting performs a soft-cancel: the task leaves the active board but its timesheet rows are preserved so billing history stays intact. If you truly need to purge history, that is an administrator action and is discouraged - cancelled state plus audit trail is the intended record.

Q12. Where do post-mortem ratings actually go?

Two places: the contribution metrics flow into the Performance module as appraisal evidence, and skill upgrade suggestions notify HR, who update the employee's master skill inventory. Both loops immediately influence future matchmaking scores - the system literally remembers who delivered.

12. Glossary

Definitions below are operational - what the term means inside this module - rather than textbook definitions. Where a term has a configured parameter, the default is noted.

Term	Meaning in this module
Intake	The Stage-1 submission (form plus approval chain) that turns a proposal into an active project; final approval triggers workspace automation
Methodology selector	The mandatory Agile / Scrum versus Waterfall choice on the intake form; drives the planning toolkit and controls
Approval tier / chain	One step (and the ordered sequence of steps) in intake, stage-gate or timesheet routing; tiers execute strictly in order
Stage gate	A formal review routing a deliverable or phase through the gate chain; final approval stamps the linked milestone
Phase gate (time-logging lock)	Waterfall rule blocking timesheet rows on a phase until the preceding phase's gate is approved
Soft allocation	A bench reservation that blocks capacity and shows on calendars without committing the employee
Confirmed allocation	Active membership on a project with role, notifications, assignee eligibility and timesheet routing
Matchmaking score	0-100 ranking of a candidate for a role requirement (skills about 60 percent, capacity 25 percent, context 15 percent)
Bench	The pool of employees with available capacity relative to the selected window
Over-allocation threshold	Weekly combined-allocation limit that raises planner alerts (default 100 percent)
Backup hand-off	Notification to PMs when an allocated member's approved leave reaches the trigger (default 5 working days)
Sprint	A fixed-length Agile iteration; one active sprint per project pod (lock enforced)
Story points	Agile sizing unit on tasks; committed versus completed points drive velocity and say-do
Velocity	Story points completed in a sprint; trended on the Sprints tab
Say-do ratio	Completed divided by committed points for a sprint; 100 percent means exact delivery
Burndown	Remaining-points view of the active sprint showing burn rate against the ideal line
Phase	A sequential Waterfall delivery window with dates and an optional budget cap

Term	Meaning in this module
Budget cap / slippage	Per-phase cost ceiling; logged-cost computed from encrypted cost rates is compared against it
Milestone	A dated, gate-stamped marker of acceptance; milestone variance feeds closure readiness
Billable / non-billable	The financial flag on each timesheet row determining whether it flows to invoicing
Readiness report	The live closure report: hours, actual cost, budget and milestone variance, task stats, compliance items
Post-mortem	Per-member closure ratings (delivery quality, communication, speed) plus skill upgrade suggestions feeding Performance and the skill inventory
Workspace automation	The final-approval trigger creating the project chat room and the kanban board seeded from tasks
Two-way kanban sync	Card moves on the Delivery Board and the Collaboration board update each other, including completedAt stamps
Integration sync	Import, push and status-mapped transitions between project tasks and Jira / Azure DevOps issues; tokens stored encrypted

Table 12-1: Glossary of module terminology